



Gruta do Janelão

Location Minas Gerais state, eastern Brazil

This impressive limestone cave system in the valley of the Peruaçu River has many interesting features but is most famous for its rock art, which is more than 4,000 years old. The Peruaçu runs through part of the 3-mile- (4.7-km-) long system. Spectacular features include the tallest free-standing stalagmite in the world, which is 92 ft (28 m) from top to bottom, and one chamber that is 330 ft (100 m) from floor to ceiling. In places, sinkholes admit enough light through the cave roof for vegetation to grow within.

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Europe

Dettifoss

Location Vatnajökull National Park, northeast Iceland

Fed by meltwater from the Vatnajökull Glacier, Dettifoss is often described as the most powerful waterfall in Europe, based on its drop of 144 ft (44 m) and width of 330 ft (100 m). It is fed by the sediment-rich waters of the Jökulsá River, which flows from Vatnajökull across columnar basalt before thundering over the sheer cliff of Dettifoss. The water ranges from grayish white to brownish white, depending on

the sediment load. The average flow is 6,180 cubic feet (175 cubic meters) per second.

Seljalandsfoss

Location South Region, Iceland

This waterfall carries the waters of the Seljalands River 200 ft (60 m) over an ancient sea cliff into a pool and then to the coast. Unusually, it is possible to walk behind the fall as it pours over an overhang where resistant solidified lava lies on top of less resistant tillite (a glacial deposit). The river is fed by meltwater from the Eyjafjallajökull ice cap, lying on the caldera of the active volcano of the same name (which last erupted in 2010).

Skógafoss

Location South Region, Iceland

This is one of Iceland’s most famous waterfalls, where the Skógá River thunders down a drop of 200 ft (60 m), producing clouds of spray—and rainbows on sunny days. Skógafoss is the most impressive of many falls that plunge down the basalt cliffs marking the position of the 3,000-year-old former coastline. This relic shoreline, now 3 miles (5 km) inland, dates from the last ice age, when Iceland was covered in ice; the coastline has subsequently fallen as the land has rebounded upward following the melting of the ice.

▼ WATER CASCADING FROM BASALT CLIFFS AT SKÓGAFOSS



dividing Paraguay into two, with alluvial savanna (the Gran Chaco) to the west and wetter, forested regions to the east. The river is navigable for a greater length than any other river on the continent apart from the Amazon. Fishes such as the salmonlike dorado, the piranha, and the basslike pacu inhabit the Paraguay River.